

VERSE & VALE

GRIT-AND-CLAY PIXEL PALETTE

A limited earth-tone system for a narrative pixel-art game set in Nebuchadnezzar II’s Neo-Babylonian Empire (605-536 BC). Sun-bleached ochre and weathered clay dominate; muted lapis and gold, drawn from the Ishtar Gate glaze, carry royalty and light.

01 MASTER RAMPS

Umber / Ink					outlines • deepest shadow • text				
Ink	Bitumen	Deep Umber	Umber	Raw Umber					
#1E140C	#2B1D12	#382819	#483520	#63492A					
OUTLINE	INK	SHADOW	SHADOW	SHADOW					

Clay / Ochre					mudbrick • core architecture				
Mudbrick Shadow	Clay	Ochre	Sunbrick	Pale Ochre					
#6C4D2C	#87683D	#9A7847	#AC884D	#C7A263					
SHADOW	SHADOW	MID	MID	HIGH					

Sand / Linen					pale ground • parchment • robes				
Sand	Linen	Parchment	Flax	Bleached Linen					
#CDA766	#D8C291	#E0D3AE	#BCB192	#EBD9B0					
MID	HIGH	HIGH	MID	HIGH					

Limestone / Stone				quarried stone · pavers · walls
Quarry Shadow	Grey Stone	Limestone	Pale Stone	Weathered Stone
#6A6058	#7D705E	#9A938A	#A89A84	#C2A068
SHADOW	SHADOW	MID	MID	HIGH

Basalt / Dark Stone				basalt terrain · deep masonry
Basalt Shadow	Basalt	Slate	Dark Masonry	Masonry
#2A2A30	#3A3A42	#55555C	#634528	#7A5836
SHADOW	SHADOW	MID	SHADOW	MID

Lapis / Glazed Brick				Ishtar glaze · royalty · night
Night Lapis	Dusk Blue	Glaze Shadow	Lapis	Bright Lapis
#232B47	#373A4C	#38476D	#3E5C99	#5A79B0
SHADOW	SHADOW	MID	ACCENT	ACCENT

Gold / Brass				royal metal · vessels · lamplight
Brass Shadow	Brass	Old Gold	Gold	Lamplight
#A8843C	#C7A263	#CAA565	#EBB96A	#F5D488
SHADOW	MID	MID	ACCENT	ACCENT

Furnace / Fire				heat · danger · Ch.3 glow
Ember Shadow	Ember	Flame	Fire	Furnace Glow
#7B3D2B	#A8522D	#C86A2E	#E58A3A	#F4B24A
SHADOW	SHADOW	MID	ACCENT	ACCENT

Garden / Life-Green				Ch.4 garden · vegetation · marsh
Deep Foliage	Marsh Green	Leaf	Green	Bright Leaf
#2F4A24	#3D652B	#547833	#6D983C	#86B551
SHADOW	SHADOW	MID	MID	HIGH

Water / Turquoise				Euphrates · fountains
Deep Water	Euphrates	Turquoise	Fountain	Bright Turquoise
#1C545C	#276A72	#4A9899	#4FA0A0	#7FC6BF
SHADOW	SHADOW	MID	MID	HIGH

Royal Purple			royalty accent · use sparingly
Royal Shadow	Tyrian	Royal Purple	
#3E1E33	#5E2A46	#833A63	
SHADOW	MID	ACCENT	

02

SKIN TONES

A warm Near-Eastern range in three tones. Each reads shadow, base, highlight; all figures still take the single deep-umber outline.

Tone 1		
Shadow #A8724A	Base #D9A579	Highlight #ECC79B

Tone 2		
Shadow #8A5A36	Base #C08A5A	Highlight #D8A877

Tone 3		
Shadow #6B472B	Base #9A6844	Highlight #B98A5E

03

ELEMENT CATEGORIES

CHARACTERS

Skin

Sand/Linen

Lapis

Gold

Royal Purple

Umber

Judean youths (Daniel, Hananiah, Mishael, Azariah) in undyed Sand/Linen wool; the Babylonian court in Lapis and Gold; Royal purple reserved for Nebuchadnezzar and Belshazzar. Every sprite: 4-6 colours and one Umber outline.

■ ENVIRONMENTS

Clay · Limestone · Umber · Lapis · Gold · Furnace · Garden



Mudbrick and limestone build the architecture; Umber gives shadow depth; Lapis and Gold glaze the royal facades; the Furnace ramp lights the fiery courtyard; the Garden ramp fills the wilderness. Lamplight picks from Gold.

■ OBJECTS

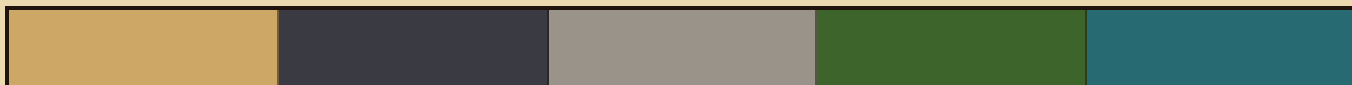
Clay · Limestone · Gold · Lapis · Umber



Jars, altars, idols, the ziggurat, carts and vessels sit in Clay and Limestone; Gold or Lapis pick out sacred and royal items. Each prop shares the Umber outline and stays 1-2 shades off its background so it reads small.

■ PLOTS

Sand · Basalt · Limestone · Garden · Water



Ground plates and terrain patches under scenes. Keep these slightly lower in contrast than the characters and objects placed on them so figures pop.

■ TILES

Basalt · Clay · Garden · Limestone · Sand · Water



Repeating terrain (cracked clay, marsh, pavers, sand, basalt, water) tuned to tile seamlessly. Keep within-tile contrast gentle so tiled fields do not shimmer.

COLOUR ROLES

**Outline / Ink**

The single deep-umber step every sprite shares; the whole game reads as one hand.

**Shadow**

The darkest steps of each ramp; occlusion and form under-planes.

**Midtone**

The ramp core, most of a sprite's fill lives here.

**Highlight**

Palest steps plus Lamplight; small catchlights and sun-struck edges.

**Accent**

Lapis, Gold, Furnace, Water and Royal purple, for emphasis, used sparingly.

THE RULES

- Every element shares one deep Umber outline (#1E140C); this cohesion is non-negotiable across characters, objects and environments.
- This is pixel art: hard edges, no gradients, no anti-aliasing. Keep a limited palette per sprite (4-6 colours).
- Let earth tones dominate. Cap accents at 1-2 hues per sprite; Royal purple only on Nebuchadnezzar and Belshazzar.
- Read at size: keep any foreground fill 1-2 steps off its background and never adjacent on the same ramp.
- Do not add colours outside these ramps. If a value must shift to stay readable, show the original and the fix side by side and say why.

05 **READABILITY CHECK**

The shared umber outline is what guarantees separation at mobile pixel size. Test every sprite on both its palest ground (Sand) and darkest ground (Basalt). Each swatch pair below is a stand-in sprite palette (outline, robe/base, fill, and accent) sitting on the two extreme plots.

On Pale Plots • Sand

#CDA766



OUTLINE



LINEN



LAPIS



GOLD

On Dark Plots • Basalt

#2A2A30



OUTLINE



SKIN



LAPIS



LEAF

CONTRAST NOTE • SMALL MOBILE SPRITES

At sprite scale, keep the foreground fill 1-2 steps off its ground and never adjacent on the same ramp. Watch mid-lapis (#3E5C99) on night-lapis (#232B47) and basalt (#3A3A42); add a Bright Lapis (#5A79B0) or Lamplight (#F5D488) rim so the silhouette survives. Gold vessels and green foliage read cleanly on both plots thanks to the umber outline.

Pixel art • hard edges • no gradients • no anti-aliasing • 4-6 colours per sprite

SINGLE UMBER OUTLINE • #1E140C